

Passages - Phaedo

What a strange thing it seems, gentlemen, this thing men call pleasure. And how surprisingly connected with its apparent opposite, pain. They won't come to a man both together, but ; you go after one of them and get it, you're always pretty well bound to get the other as well

For those who have genuinely been engaged in philosophy in the truest sense of the word, dying and being dead are just exactly what they've been practising. That, and nothing else. And if that's the case, there would be some absurdity, I imagine, in spending your whole life looking forward to this one thing, and then when it came, getting upset at what you had been looking forward to and practising for.

That the man who has no interest in the pleasures which come from the body is only one remove from being dead?

'Isn't it in reasoning, then, if anywhere, that any of the things that are become clear to it?'

'Yes.'

"And it reasons best, I take it, when none of those things troubles it - neither hearing nor sight, neither pain nor pleasure - when it is as much on its own as it can be, when it pays no attention to the body, has as little to do with it as possible, avoids touching it, and so reaches out for what is.'

'That is so.'

'So here too the soul of the philosopher treats the body with d complete contempt, avoiding it and trying to get to be alone by itself.'

'Wouldn't this be done most purely by the

man who approaches each one as far as possible with thought alone, without taking sight into account at all in his thinking, and not dragging in any other sense as a partner in his reasoning? He uses thought in its pure form, all by itself, in an attempt to track down each one of the things that are, in its pure form, just by itself. He frees himself, as far as possible, from his eyes, ears, and to all intents and purposes from the whole of his body, in the belief that it is a distraction, and that when it is in partnership with the soul the body stops it acquiring truth and knowledge.

"So if you see a man getting upset at the prospect of dying. isn't that a clear indication that he wasn't a lover of wisdom, after all, but a lover of the body.

the soul is most like what is divine immortal, the object of thought, of one single form, indestructible, and remaining ever constant and true to itself, whereas the body is most like what is human, mortal, of many forms, not the object of thought, destructible, and never remaining true to itself?

As far as I can see, if there is something else beautiful, apart from the beautiful itself, there can be no reason for its being beautiful other than that it shares in that beautiful.

"In which case,' he said, 'I can no longer understand or recognise all those other clever reasons. The safe answer to give myself or anyone else will be that it is the beautiful which makes beautiful things beautiful.

You'd proclaim that you know no way for any given thing to come into being other than by sharing in the particular being of

each thing it does share in, and that in these instances you can allow no cause of two coming to be other than its sharing in twoness. Things which are going to be two must share in this, and anything which is going to be one must share in oneness.

If the immortal is also indestructible, then it's impossible for the soul to be destroyed when death comes against it. What we've just been saying suggests that it will not admit death, nor will it be dead, just as we say three will not be even, any more than the odd will. Nor will fire be cold, any more than the heat in the fire.